embassy. The key sentence of the addendum read: “N. S. Khrushchev believes that it would be good if the President in his statements at the news conference did not introduce elements of aggravation and did not make any statements hurting the national feelings of the Cubans.”

The impetus to add these points came from Mikoyan, who had finally convinced Castro to bow to the inevitable withdrawal of the bombers but missed the boat by a few hours. He managed to secure the agreement late in the evening of November 19, which was early morning in Moscow. By the time his reports were printed for distribution to the members of the Presidium, Khrushchev’s letter had already gone to the Soviet embassy in Washington. All they could do was amend the letter to take into account Castro’s concerns about Kennedy’s forthcoming statement.[5]

Unbeknownst to Kennedy and his advisers, there was at least one false statement in Khrushchev’s letter to Kennedy. It read: “All the nuclear weapons have been taken away from Cuba.” That statement was correct as it pertained to the ballistic missiles, but the nuclear bombs for IL-28s and the tactical nuclear weapons remained in Cuba. Americans knew nothing about them, but Khrushchev apparently decided not to play any more with nuclear fire. He was determined to remove the tactical nukes as well. On November 20, the same day he sent his letter to Kennedy, Marshal Malinovsky issued an order to General Pliev in Cuba: “Missiles with conventional loads for ‘Luna’ and FKR [cruise missiles] should be left in Cuba. Send 6 nuclear bombs, 12 warheads for ‘Luna’ and 80 warheads for FKR to the Soviet Union on steamship “Atkarsk.”[6]

Khrushchev was cleaning up his act; everything seemed to be under control. But once again Castro spoiled the game. On November 22, an alarmed Mikoyan informed Khrushchev that the Cubans had sent word to their United Nations representative, Carlos Lechuga, that they were in possession of the tactical nuclear weapons. They let the Soviet ambassador, Alekseev, know of their instructions challenging the Soviet resolve to remove all nuclear weapons from the island. Mikoyan urged Khrushchev to prevent this Cuban maneuver, proposing that he deceitfully invoke a nonexistent Soviet law prohibiting the transfer of nuclear weapons to other countries.